
Los Angeles Regional Water Quality Control Board

August 14, 2025

Scott Meckstroth
General Manager
Ojai Valley Sanitary District
1072 Tico Road
Ojai, CA 93023

PROPOSED 90-DAY OPERATIONS PLAN FOR NEW BIOLOGICAL TREATMENT PROCESS – OJAI VALLEY SANITARY DISTRICT (OVSD), OJAI VALLEY WASTEWATER TREATMENT PLANT (OVWWTP) (ORDER NO. R4-2023-0430, NPDES PERMIT NO. CA0053961, CI-4245)

Dear Scott Meckstroth,

On June 24, 2025, Los Angeles Regional Water Quality Control Board (Los Angeles Water Board) staff met with OVSD staff to discuss nitrite effluent exceedances in the OVWWTP effluent and the mitigation measures that have been implemented. OVSD expressed the need to troubleshoot the nitrite issue and indicated additional time is needed to adjust and test the denitrification system. On July 28, 2025, OVSD submitted a letter to the Los Angeles Water Board including a filter testing report and an Operations Plan for the newly constructed biological treatment process at the OVWWTP and requesting that mandatory minimum penalties for nitrite-related effluent limitation exceedances be waived for a 90-day period, commencing on August 18, 2025, to allow for additional adjusting and testing of the biological treatment process at the OVWWTP, pursuant to subdivision “j” of Section 13385 of the California Water Code (CWC).

On August 4, 2025, Los Angeles Water Board staff provided comments on the Operations Plan. On August 8, 2025, OVSD submitted responses to the Los Angeles Water Board’s comments with a revised Operations Plan. The Los Angeles Water Board staff has reviewed the OVSD’s responses and the revised Operations Plan, finds that OVSD addressed all comments, and has no objection to the Operations Plan dated August 8, 2025.

In terms of compliance with mandatory minimum penalties, the Los Angeles Water Board cannot waive mandatory minimum penalties for exceedances of the nitrite-related effluent limitations that may occur during the testing period for the secondary and tertiary treatment process at this time since additional requirements must first be met. Pursuant to subdivision (j)(1)(D)(i) of section 13385 of the CWC, mandatory minimum penalties do not apply to “[T]he operation of a new or reconstructed wastewater treatment unit during a defined period of adjusting or testing, not to exceed 90 days for

DAVID NAHAI, CHAIR | SUSANA ARREDONDO, EXECUTIVE OFFICER

a wastewater treatment plant that relies on a biological treatment process and not to exceed 30 days for any other wastewater treatment unit... ” provided that certain conditions are met, including, but not limited to, the submission of and compliance with an operations plan. (Wat. Code, § 13385(j)(1)(D).) OVSD has submitted a revised Operations Plan, but a determination of compliance with the nitrite-related effluent limitations cannot be made until after OVSD demonstrates it has complied with all other applicable requirements in subdivision (j)(1)(D)(i)(I-V) of section 13385 of the CWC.

If you have any questions, please contact [Steven Webb](#) at Steven.Webb@Waterboards.ca.gov or at (213) 576-6793, or [Don Tsai](#) at Don.Tsai@Waterboards.ca.gov or at (213) 576-6681.

Sincerely,

for Susana Arredondo
Executive Officer
Los Angeles Regional Water Quality Control Board